

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	Medium

Question

Why do sand cats purr but lions roar? Researchers hypothesize that this difference between the two feline species may be partly due to a U-shaped bone in their throats called the hyoid. Sand cats, which are much smaller than lions, have a rigid hyoid that rumbles when the cat’s larynx vibrates, resulting in a purr. By contrast, lions have a somewhat flexible hyoid, and the bone is attached to the skull with a stretchy ligament that sand cats lack. These traits allow lions and most other species of big cats to produce powerful roars. The same traits may also prevent most big cats from purring.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

Answer

- A. The text presents a theory about two species, then discusses facts that weaken it.
- B. The text compares the habitats of two species, then explains how those habitats are changing.
- C. The text describes a behavior shared by two species, then discusses other behaviors shared by them.
- D. The text poses a question about two species, then presents a possible answer.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it best describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by posing a question about two different cat species: "Why do sand cats purr but lions roar?" The remainder of the text then presents a possible answer to this question by explaining a hypothesis about differences in these cats’ hyoid bone structure. The text details how sand cats have rigid hyoids that produce purring sounds when their larynx vibrates, while lions have more flexible hyoids attached to the skull with a stretchy ligament that enables roaring but may prevent purring.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t present facts that weaken the theory about two cat species; rather, it asks a question about two species and then discusses a potential answer. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss the habitats of sand cats and lions at all, nor does it mention any changes to their habitats. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t describe a behavior shared by the two cat species mentioned. On the contrary, it specifically focuses on the different vocalization behaviors of each species (purring versus roaring) and why those differences may exist.